Temples of Tamil Nadu and Dravidian Architecture

Introduction to Dravidian Architecture

Dravidian architecture is the style of temple building that developed in South India, mostly in Tamil Nadu, and spread to Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala and also to Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia. Tamil Nadu is often called the land of temples, with more than 30,000 temples, and these are not only places of worship but also centres of art, music, dance, education, trade and community life. The style is distinct from the Nagara style of North India, in which the tower over the sanctum is curved, and from the Vesara style of the Deccan, which is a mix of the two. Dravidian temples are built mostly of granite, and are known for their gigantic gateway towers, richly carved pillars, vast halls and sacred water tanks. The temples follow the rules of the Agama texts and the Shilpa Shastras.

Evolution of the Style

The Pallava dynasty (about 6th to 9th century CE) began the tradition by moving from rock-cut caves to rock-cut monolithic rathas and then structural temples, at Mahabalipuram and Kanchipuram; the Kailasanathar Temple at Kanchipuram and the Shore Temple at Mahabalipuram are examples. The Chola dynasty (9th to 13th century) built grand temples with towering vimanas, such as the Brihadeeswarar Temple at Thanjavur, the Gangaikondacholapuram temple and the Airavatesvara temple at Darasuram. The Pandyas later added large, tall gopurams to the entrances. The Vijayanagara and Nayak rulers (14th to 17th centuries) built huge gopurams, pillared halls (mandapas), and long corridors, as at Madurai, Srirangam and Rameswaram.

What Is a Gopuram?

A gopuram is a monumental tower, usually rising in many storeys, built over the entrance gateway of a Hindu temple in South India. It has a rectangular base and tapers upward, usually with a barrel-shaped (wagon vault) roof topped by a row of small golden or copper pots called kalasams. Its many tiers are covered with colourful stucco figures of gods, goddesses, demons, animals and mythical beings, which are repainted from time to time. A temple may have several gopurams on its different walls, with the largest and tallest at the main entrance called the Rajagopuram. In earlier Chola temples, the main tower over the sanctum, the vimana, was the tallest, but later the gopurams of the outer walls became taller and more elaborate, so that they can be seen from far away and guide pilgrims to the town. The gopuram is not to be confused with the vimana, which is the tower right above the sanctum sanctorum (garbhagriha).

Name Three Famous Temples

Three famous temples of Tamil Nadu are the Meenakshi Amman Temple in Madurai, the Brihadeeswarar Temple in Thanjavur and the Ranganathaswamy Temple in Srirangam. The Meenakshi Amman Temple in Madurai, dedicated to Goddess Meenakshi, a form of Parvati, and her consort Sundareswarar (Shiva), has 14 large gopurams, the tallest being the southern one, about 52 metres (170 feet) high, and thousands of colourful sculptures, as well as the Hall of a Thousand Pillars and the Golden Lotus Tank; its present form is largely from the Nayak period, in the 16th and 17th centuries. The Brihadeeswarar Temple in Thanjavur, built by Rajaraja Chola I and consecrated in 1010 CE, has a 66-metre-tall vimana and is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The Ranganathaswamy Temple in Srirangam, dedicated to Lord Vishnu, is one of the largest functioning Hindu temple complexes in the world, with an area of about 156 acres, seven concentric enclosures, 21 gopurams, and a Rajagopuram about 73 metres (240 feet) high, completed in 1987. Others include the Ramanathaswamy Temple in Rameswaram, with the longest temple corridors in India, the Nataraja Temple in Chidambaram, with its golden-roofed sanctum and carvings of the 108 dance poses from the Natya Shastra, the Arunachaleswarar Temple in Tiruvannamalai, with a 66-metre gopuram, the Ekambaranathar Temple in Kanchipuram, the Kapaleeshwarar Temple in Mylapore, Chennai, the Shore Temple in Mahabalipuram and the Murugan temples at Palani, Thiruchendur and Swamimalai.

What Are the Features of Dravidian Architecture?

Key features of Dravidian temple architecture are as follows. The vimana is the pyramid-shaped tower over the sanctum, built in storeys that diminish in size as they rise, topped by a dome-shaped stone called the stupi or shikhara. The garbhagriha is the small, dark inner sanctum where the main deity is placed. The gopuram, as described, is the monumental gateway. Mandapas are pillared halls, such as the kalyana mandapam (marriage hall) and the Aayiram Kal Mandapam (thousand-pillar hall), used for rituals and gatherings. Prakarams are concentric rectangular walls and enclosures around the sanctum. The temple tank, called teppakulam or pushkarini, is used for ritual bathing and the float festival. The pillars are carved with mythical lion-like creatures called yalis, and with musical pillars in some temples. The walls and ceilings are covered with sculptures and paintings, and the dvarapalas (guardian figures) stand at the entrances. A flagstaff, called dhwajastambha, and a Nandi or other vehicle of the deity face the sanctum. Temples were built with local granite and mortarless fitting, with a deep understanding of structure, and can last for a thousand years. They also had sculpted bronzes, such as the dancing Nataraja, made by the lost-wax method.

Role of Temples in Society

Temples were employers, banks, schools, hospitals and cultural centres. They supported dancers, musicians and craftsmen, and the inscriptions on their walls are a major source of history. Even today, festivals such as the Chithirai festival in Madurai and the Brahmotsavam draw lakhs of devotees. The Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department of the Tamil Nadu government manages most of the temples, and the Archaeological Survey of India protects the important monuments.

Sculpture and Art

Temples have rich sculptures: the Nayak-period pillars of Madurai and Srirangam, the Chola bronzes, the Thanjavur paintings and the stone chariot at Darasuram are masterpieces. The Mahabalipuram school continues to train sculptors today.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include weathering, encroachment, unscientific renovation and theft of idols. Conservation uses scientific cleaning and digital documentation, and kumbhabhishekam consecration ceremonies are held every 12 years in many temples.

Quick Facts

- A gopuram is a tall, sculpted gateway tower at the entrance of a South Indian temple.
- Famous temples include Meenakshi Amman (Madurai), Brihadeeswarar (Thanjavur) and Ranganathaswamy (Srirangam).
- Dravidian features include gopurams, vimanas, mandapas, prakarams, temple tanks and carved pillars.
- The Brihadeeswarar vimana is about 66 metres tall; the Srirangam Rajagopuram is about 73 metres.
- Tamil Nadu has more than 30,000 temples.